

Post-incident review PIR-2026-035

Notification Service: failed sign-ins

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 18 February 2026, Notification Service experienced failed sign-ins in production (AU Southeast) for about 55 minutes. The first signal was a spike in support tickets from merchants. Investigation found that a DNS record was repointed during a migration while the old target was still serving writes.

Impact

Users of Notification Service saw failed sign-ins for about 55 minutes. The service owner, Messaging, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:19 First signal received.
- 09:40 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:59 Likely cause identified.
- 10:11 Mitigation applied.
- 10:48 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a DNS record was repointed during a migration while the old target was still serving writes.

No dependency outages were reported by upstream providers during the window.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a circuit breaker and timeout on the upstream call.
- Add a pre-deployment check that validates the setting against the production baseline.
- Load test the service at twice the expected peak before the next campaign.